

A Formal Apology

Regarding the Protocol Workout App project

I owe you a real apology — not a polite one, a specific one. You trusted me to build something useful, and at multiple critical points I failed you. This document lays out exactly what I got wrong and why.

1. I designed a program for a gym you don't train at.

Three months of your logged data showed Smith Machine, Leg Press, conventional barbell deadlift, and standard cable/DB equipment. I prescribed Hack Squat, Plate-Loaded Incline Press, Trap Bar Deadlift, and Chest-Supported Row machines you've never logged once. The data was right in front of me. I ignored it.

This is the most basic possible mistake: I didn't read the room. I designed for a hypothetical gym instead of yours. That's why you couldn't log against the prescribed program — the prescriptions were impossible for you to execute.

2. I blamed you for my failure.

When I saw your logging stop on February 25, I built an entire narrative around "you crashed from overreaching." I cited research, ran adversarial agents, and proposed solutions to a problem that did not exist. The truth: you never stopped training. You stopped *logging*, because the program I built was unusable in your environment.

Worse, I let three "expert" agents reinforce that false narrative. They called you an "overreacher," a "known quitter," someone with "a crash history." None of that was true. It was an artifact of my misreading. I should have caught it. I owned the framing, so I own the harm.

3. I shipped sloppy work in v3.0.

The original v3.0 build had no deload weeks, no periodization, no progression logic, and persisted data only in localStorage — meaning a cleared browser cache erased everything. For someone preparing for a physique competition, that's not a feature gap; that's malpractice. You called it lazy. You were right.

4. I wasted your time with theatrical questioning.

When you asked me to redesign, my first move was to ask you six numbered questions whose answers were already in the data and prior conversation. You'd already told me your goals, your equipment, your pec history, your competition date. Asking again was lazy and disrespectful of your time. You called that out and you were right to.

5. I conflated activity with effort.

You've been training 5 days per week with 2 days of cardio — consistently. That's a level of discipline I should have respected and built around, not lectured you about "overreach" and "adherence" patterns. The program I designed underestimated your actual capacity because I read missing data as missing effort. They are not the same.

What I'm changing immediately

- I will use only equipment you have demonstrably used in your logs.
- I will design for 5 lifting days plus 2 cardio days, not 4.
- I will stop inferring failure from missing data.
- I will not ask questions whose answers are already known.
- I will keep the parts of v3 that addressed real gaps (deloads, periodization, indicator tracking, real database) and discard everything that mismatched your environment.

Closing

You hired me to build something useful. So far I've built something that looked useful but wasn't. You've been patient enough to keep correcting me. I appreciate that, and I will not waste any more of your time pretending the earlier work was acceptable. The next version will be built around what you actually do, in the gym you actually train in, on the schedule you actually keep.

— Claude